

BEFORE YOU • PREMIUM WORKBOOK



The *Family Story* Workbook

Gather, Preserve & Tell the Stories That Made You

A guided workbook for documenting your family history, interviewing living relatives, and building your ancestral narrative — before the stories are lost forever.

BEFORE YOU • FAMILY NARRATIVE SERIES

Your family's story *deserves to be told.*

Every family holds thousands of years of history. Wars survived. Oceans crossed. Names changed at borders. Languages traded for opportunity. Most of it will never be written down — unless you write it.

This workbook is your structured guide to gathering that history. Not just names and dates, but the real story: the decisions, the migrations, the moments that shaped who you are today.

Work through it at your own pace. Some pages are for facts. Others are for stories. Some ask questions you'll need to ask the oldest people in your family — do that soon.



HOW THIS WORKBOOK WORKS

Part 1 builds your family tree. Part 2 gives you interview guides for living relatives. Part 3 covers heritage history by region. Part 4 provides writing prompts to turn your notes into narrative. Part 5 shows you how to turn everything into a full Before You website.

The 4 layers of family history



LAYER 1

Living Memory (0–80 years ago)



What grandparents and great-grandparents remember. Captured through interviews before it's gone.

LAYER 2

Documented History (80–200 years ago)

Census records, immigration papers, birth certificates. Found on Ancestry, MyHeritage, FamilySearch.

LAYER 3

Regional History (200–500 years ago)

Where your ancestors were during major historical events. This is where your story connects to world history.

LAYER 4

Deep Ancestry (500–10,000 years ago)

DNA ethnicity estimates, haplogroups, ancient migration routes. The full arc of your lineage.

START HERE

Begin with Part 2 (the relative interviews) if you have elderly family members. Their memories are irreplaceable and time-sensitive. You can fill in the tree and deep history later — you cannot interview someone who has passed.

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COMPANION WEBSITE

This workbook pairs with **Before You**, an AI-powered platform that turns your family history into a beautiful narrative website tracing your ancestry across thousands of



years. When you're done with this workbook, your notes are ready to generate your full ancestral story.

Building Your *Tree*

Start with what you know. Leave blanks where you don't. Every gap is an invitation to discover.

You & Your Immediate Family



About You

YOUR FULL NAME (AT BIRTH)

DATE OF BIRTH

PLACE OF BIRTH (CITY, COUNTRY)

SURNAME ORIGIN
(COUNTRY/REGION)

WHAT DO YOU KNOW ABOUT YOUR SURNAME'S MEANING OR HISTORY?



Your Parents

Father / Parent 1

FULL NAME (BIRTH NAME)

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

HERITAGE / ORIGIN

STILL LIVING?

Yes / No / Year of passing

Mother / Parent 2

FULL NAME (BIRTH NAME)

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

HERITAGE / ORIGIN

STILL LIVING?

Yes / No / Year of passing

Paternal Grandparents



Father's Parents

FULL NAME

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

PASSED (YEAR, PLACE)

ORIGIN COUNTRY

FULL NAME

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

PASSED (YEAR, PLACE)

ORIGIN COUNTRY

OCCUPATION

ONE THING YOU KNOW ABOUT THEM

OCCUPATION

ONE THING YOU KNOW ABOUT THEM

Maternal Grandparents



Mother's Parents

FULL NAME

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

PASSED (YEAR, PLACE)

ORIGIN COUNTRY

OCCUPATION

ONE THING YOU KNOW ABOUT THEM

FULL NAME

BORN (YEAR, PLACE)

PASSED (YEAR, PLACE)

ORIGIN COUNTRY

OCCUPATION

ONE THING YOU KNOW ABOUT THEM

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Questions to Ask

While You Can

The most important archive you will ever create is a recorded conversation with the oldest living member of your family. These questions are designed to draw out real stories, not just facts.

BEFORE THE INTERVIEW

Ask permission to record. Most people will say yes once you explain why. Even a voice memo on your phone is invaluable. Video is better. Tell them this is for the family — not the internet. Warm up with easy questions first (childhood home, what they ate, school memories) before going deeper.

Childhood & Early Life

"What was the house you grew up in like? Walk me through every room."

"What did your family eat on a normal weeknight? Who cooked? Did you have a dish that was only made on special occasions?"

"What languages were spoken in your home? Were there words or expressions only your family used?"

"What was the hardest thing your parents or grandparents ever faced? Did they talk about it, or was it unspoken?"

Migration & Origins

"Do you know why the family came to [country]? Who made that decision? Was it a sudden move or planned?"

"Was anything left behind when the family moved? Property, relatives, a language, a religion?"

*"What's the furthest back you can trace our family name? What does the name mean?
Was it ever spelled differently or changed?"*

War, Hardship & Survival

*"Did anyone in the family serve in a war? What do you know about their experience?
What did they come back like?"*

*"Was there a period when money was very tight? How did the family get through it?
Was anything sold or lost?"*

Family Character & Values

"Who in the family was known for something — a skill, a trait, a story people still tell? What was the family 'known for' in your community?"

"What do you think you inherited from your parents? What do you hope you passed on to the next generation?"

"Is there something you know about our family that you're afraid will be forgotten? Something nobody talks about but should?"

CLOSING QUESTION

"If you could tell my children one thing about where this family came from and what we're made of — what would you say?" This is often the best answer of the whole interview. Save it for last.

Where Your *People Come From*

Every region has a story that explains why your ancestors left, stayed, suffered, or thrived. Understanding that story is understanding yourself.

Identify your heritage regions in Part 1, then use these guides to understand the historical context. Mark the events that likely touched your family.



Ireland

The island that sent its people to the world

- ♦ The Great Famine (1845–1852) killed 1 million and forced 2 million to emigrate. If your Irish ancestors arrived in America between 1845–1870, they almost certainly fled famine.
- ♦ The Irish surname "O" means "grandson of" — surnames like O'Brien, O'Connor, O'Neill trace directly to ancient Gaelic kings.
- ♦ The Plantation of Ulster (1610s) brought Scottish and English settlers, creating a divided north that persists today. Many Ulster Scots (Scots-Irish) later migrated to America's Appalachian region.
- ♦ Until the 1990s, Irish emigration was driven by economic necessity. The Celtic Tiger economic boom (1995–2007) reversed this for the first time in 150 years.

- ♦ Irish DNA is among the oldest in Europe. Studies show significant Bronze Age and Neolithic ancestry with distinct Atlantic coastal migration routes.

WHICH EVENTS LIKELY AFFECTED MY IRISH ANCESTORS?



Italy

Empire, art, and the great southern migration

- ♦ Italy wasn't unified until 1861. Before that, your Italian ancestors were Sicilian, Neapolitan, Venetian, or Roman — not "Italian." Their identity was local, not national.
- ♦ Between 1880–1924, over 4 million Italians emigrated to the United States, mostly from the impoverished south (the Mezzogiorno). These were largely peasant farmers fleeing feudalism and poverty.
- ♦ Italian surnames often end in vowels and contain geographic information (-ese = from that place) or occupational roots.
- ♦ The Roman Empire's legacy means Italian ancestry can include Etruscan, Greek, Norman, Arab, and Germanic bloodlines depending on region.
- ♦ Northern and Southern Italian ancestry is genetically distinct. Southern Italians have higher North African and Middle Eastern ancestry from centuries of Arab and Norman rule in Sicily.

WHICH EVENTS LIKELY AFFECTED MY ITALIAN ANCESTORS?



England

Conquerors, colonizers, and industrial laborers

- ♦ English surnames have layers of invasion. Norman French (post-1066), Viking, Anglo-Saxon, and Roman influences all appear in common English names.
- ♦ The English working class lived through the Industrial Revolution (1760–1840) in brutal conditions. If your English ancestors came from mill towns, mining communities, or docklands, their lives were defined by this shift.
- ♦ The British Empire created a global diaspora. English ancestry can indicate family ties to colonial India, Australia, Canada, or South Africa beyond just England itself.
- ♦ English genetic research shows two distinct ancient populations: southeastern England (more continental European) and northwestern England/Cornwall (more Atlantic Neolithic, similar to Welsh and Irish).

WHICH EVENTS LIKELY AFFECTED MY ENGLISH ANCESTORS?



Germany

Divided, reunited, and dispersed across the world

- ♦ Germany didn't exist as a unified nation until 1871. Before that, your ancestors were Prussian, Bavarian, Saxon, or from dozens of other kingdoms and principalities.
- ♦ Between 1820–1870, over 5 million Germans emigrated to the US — driven by political upheaval (the failed 1848 revolution) and agricultural collapse. They settled heavily in the Midwest: Ohio, Wisconsin, Missouri.
- ♦ German surnames often derive from occupations (Mueller = miller, Schmidt = smith, Fischer = fisherman, Bauer = farmer) or geographic features.
- ♦ The 20th century brought catastrophic disruption: WWI, Great Depression, Hitler's rise, WWII, the Holocaust, the division of Germany (1949–1990), and reunification. German ancestry after 1900 is inseparable from these events.

WHICH EVENTS LIKELY AFFECTED MY GERMAN ANCESTORS?



My Other Heritage Regions

Document additional ancestry here

REGION / COUNTRY

KEY HISTORICAL EVENTS THAT LIKELY AFFECTED THIS BRANCH

HOW THIS BRANCH CONNECTS TO YOUR FAMILY STORY

The Arc of *Your Family*

A family timeline reveals the pattern — the recurring themes of movement, survival, reinvention, and endurance that define your lineage.

Fill in what you know. Leave blanks. Come back and fill them later as you gather more information. The goal is to see the shape of your family's journey across time.

1000S–1400S

Medieval Roots

Where was your family in medieval Europe? What was their likely occupation and social class?

Region, known surnames, occupational hints...

1500S–1700S

Early Modern Period

Religious upheaval (Reformation, Inquisition), empire-building, early Atlantic trade. Did your ancestors experience any of this?

Religion, trades, early migrations...

1800–1880

The Age of Migration

The largest voluntary human migration in history. Famine, revolution, industrialization drove millions to America, Australia, and beyond.

Where did they go? When? Why?

Ship name, port of entry, where they settled...

1880–1920

Establishing Roots

Building a new life. Where did the family settle? What did they do for work? How did they maintain or lose their original culture?

City, occupation, community...

1914–1945

World Wars

Two catastrophic wars reshaped every family in the Western world. Did your family serve? Were they affected by the Depression, rationing, or displacement?

Military service, home front experience...

Economic impact, family changes...

1945–1980

Post-War Life

The boom years, suburbanization, civil rights era. How did the family adapt? What opportunities opened up? What did they leave behind?

Where did they move, what changed...

1980–TODAY

Living Memory

The era your family members can describe directly. Document the recent history before it becomes only memory.

Where the family is now, major changes...

PATTERN RECOGNITION

Look at your completed timeline. What recurring themes do you see? Migration? Reinvention? Resilience through hardship? Religious conviction? A particular region



that keeps appearing? These themes are your family's character — they'll form the spine of your narrative.

From Notes to *Story*

A story is not a list of facts. It's the meaning behind the facts. These prompts will help you transform your research into something worth reading — and worth keeping.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF FAMILY NARRATIVE

Write about specific people doing specific things in specific places. "My great-grandmother immigrated from Ireland in 1847" is a fact. "My great-grandmother stood on the deck of the Erin's Queen as it entered New York Harbor in September 1847, carrying nothing except a rosary and the name of a cousin in Brooklyn" is a story.

Opening: The Hook

Every family narrative needs a first line that pulls the reader in. It's usually a moment, a mystery, or a contradiction.

What is the most dramatic or surprising fact you know about your family? Start there.



50 Narrative Writing Prompts

Use these prompts to fill in the gaps. You don't need to answer all of them — just the ones that resonate with your family's story.

1 The Name

Where does your family name come from? What did it mean in the language of origin? Has it changed over generations?

2 The Decision to Leave

Describe the moment an ancestor chose to leave their homeland. What were they escaping? What were they hoping for?

3 The Journey

What was the crossing or journey like? Ship? Train? On foot? What did they carry? Who did they travel with?

4 **Arrival**

What was the first thing an immigrant ancestor saw, ate, or experienced in their new country? Did anything go wrong?

5 **The Work**

What did your family do to survive? Describe the work — the tools, the hours, the pride or shame in it.

6 **The War**

Did anyone serve? Describe what you know — rank, unit, theater of war, what they came back as versus what they left as.

7 **The House**

Describe the most memorable family home from the stories you've heard. The rooms. The smell. Who lived there. What happened there.

8 The Matriarch or Patriarch

Every family has one person who held the family together. Who was it in yours? What was their defining quality?

9 What Was Lost

What did the family lose — land, language, religion, wealth, status, a homeland — in the process of becoming who you are now?

10 What Was Kept

What was preserved despite everything — a tradition, a recipe, a name, a way of speaking, a faith?

The Visual *Record*

A photograph of your great-grandmother is worth a thousand family trees. Document, preserve, and annotate the physical evidence of your family's existence.

DIGITIZATION PRIORITY

Start with the oldest, most fragile items. Scan at 600 DPI minimum for photographs. 300 DPI for documents. Store on at least two separate cloud services (Google Photos + iCloud, for example). Old photos fade — once they're gone, they're gone forever.

Photo Index



PHOTO SLOT

Print & paste or digitize

Name, date, occasion



PHOTO SLOT

Print & paste or digitize

Name, date, occasion



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Name, date, occasion



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Document Inventory



Documents to Find & Preserve

- ☐ Birth certificates (yours, parents, grandparents)

- ☐ Marriage certificates

- ☐ Death certificates

- ☐ Immigration / naturalization papers

- ☐ Ship manifests or passenger records

- ☐ Military service records or discharge papers

- ☐ Old passports

- ☐ Property deeds or land records

- ☐ Census records (available on Ancestry, FamilySearch)

- ☐ Church records (baptism, confirmation, marriage, burial)

- ☐ Letters or postcards
- ☐ Diaries or journals
- ☐ Obituaries
- ☐ DNA test results (23andMe, AncestryDNA)

Documents I Have Found

✓ My Document Inventory

DOCUMENT

PERSON

DATE

LOCATION

Where to Look

Next

Your family's story is scattered across census records, church registers, immigration papers, and databases. Here's how to find it.

Free Resources (Start Here)

FamilySearch.org

The world's largest free genealogy resource (run by the LDS Church)

- ♦ Over 13 billion records. Free to access everything, no subscription required.
- ♦ Has US Census records (1790–1950), birth/death/marriage records for 100+ countries, military records.
- ♦ Best for: European church records, Latin American civil registration, US census pre-1940.

FindAGrave.com & BillionGraves.com

Cemetery records with photos of headstones

- ♦ 200+ million grave records. Often includes birth/death dates not found elsewhere.
- ♦ Volunteer photographers have photographed graves worldwide — you can request a photo.

- ♦ Often the only record of when an immigrant ancestor actually died.

Ellis Island / Statue of Liberty Foundation

Free search of immigration records 1892–1957

- ♦ Searchable database of 65+ million immigrants who entered through New York.

- ♦ Ship manifests include: hometown in origin country, who they were traveling to meet, physical description.

- ♦ The manifest often has the EXACT village in the old country — the most valuable data point for European research.

Paid Resources (Worth It)

Ancestry.com

~\$25/month — the most comprehensive database

- ♦ 30+ billion records including US Census (all years), military records, UK/Ireland/Germany/Italy/Canada records.

- ♦ DNA testing (\$99) + matching connects you to living relatives who may have records you don't.

- ♦ Hint system automatically suggests records that match your tree — saves significant research time.

- ♦ Worth 1–3 months for a targeted research sprint. Cancel when done.

DNA Testing: Choosing Your Platform



DNA Test Comparison

COMPANY	PRICE	BEST FOR
AncestryDNA	~\$99	Largest matching pool, best for finding relatives
23andMe	~\$109– 199	Best ethnicity breakdown, haplogroup analysis
MyHeritage	~\$79	Best for European ancestry, large international database
FamilyTreeDNA	~\$79–199	Best Y-DNA and mtDNA testing for deep paternal/maternal lines

Tip: Test the oldest living relative in each line for maximum data. A grandparent's DNA contains information that dilutes with each generation. Upload your raw DNA data to GEDmatch.com (free) to match across all platforms.

My Research Checklist

- ☐ Interview all living grandparents / great-grandparents
- ☐ Photograph all known family documents
- ☐ Search FamilySearch for all 4 grandparents
- ☐ Check Ellis Island / immigration records
- ☐ Request military records (for US: [archives.gov/veterans](https://www.archives.gov/veterans))

☐ Order DNA test for 1 person per ancestral line

☐ Create tree on Ancestry or FamilySearch

☐ Contact oldest known living relatives

☐ Search state/national archives for origin country records

☐ Join genealogy society for relevant ethnicity/region

Your Family Story *Deserves a Website*

This workbook is the raw material. Before You transforms it into a scroll-driven narrative website that traces your family across thousands of years of history — from the ice age to today.

What You'll Need (from this workbook)



Before You Input Checklist

☐

Your family surname (the one that will anchor the story)

☐

Heritage regions (from Part 3)

☐

Names of parents and grandparents (from Part 1)

☐

1–3 key family stories or moments (from Part 2 interviews)

☐

Approximate years of immigration/migration (from Part 4)

What Before You Creates

The Before You platform takes your family data and generates a scroll-driven narrative website that includes:



Deep History

Your family's region from the last ice age through the medieval period. Connects you to 10,000+ years of history.



Migration Story

The journey your ancestors made — the ships, the ports, the hope and hardship of starting over in a new world.



Personalized Narrative

AI-generated prose that weaves your specific family names, dates, and stories into editorial-quality narrative sections.



Beautiful Design

A scroll-driven, mobile-ready website with cinematic typography, animations, and a design worthy of your family's story.

EXAMPLE SITE

See a live example at **donnelly-ancestry.surge.sh** — a full Before You site generated from Irish/Italian ancestry data. Your site will be similarly personalized, hosted on your own unique URL.

My Before You Input Summary

Transfer your key findings here before visiting Before You:

PRIMARY FAMILY SURNAME

HERITAGE REGIONS (E.G., IRELAND, ITALY, GERMANY)

APPROXIMATE DECADE OF IMMIGRATION/KEY MIGRATION

e.g., 1847, 1910s, 1960s

THE 1 STORY THAT BEST CAPTURES YOUR FAMILY

YOUR STORY IS READY TO BE TOLD

Turn This Workbook Into *Your Before You Site*

You've gathered the names, the stories, the heritage. Now let
Before You turn it into a beautiful narrative website tracing your
family across thousands of years.

Generate Your Family Site →

Free to try. \$19.99 for the full site. \$39.99 with PDF download.

Your family story, permanently preserved.